

Chapter 31 Part 1

"You need to view films with an artistic eye" were words that came from Liang Shi's own mouth.

Now being lightly questioned back by Xu Qingzhu, especially with her clear and cold voice, the rising intonation at the end of her question, and the hint of a smile between her brows and eyes.

It was difficult to discern whether it was mockery or sarcasm.

Or perhaps just simple teasing.

In any case, it made Liang Shi's face flush with heat, even her ears turning red.

"Do you have anything else? I need to work." Xu Qingzhu was the first to break the silence, then added, "Can I use the computer in the study? I need to look at some design drafts."

Minghui Jewelry's annual new product launch was of paramount importance, and Xu Qingzhu's airborne arrival at the company coincided precisely with this year's autumn launch.

There were less than half a month remaining, and the design department had only finalized the preliminary drafts.

Due to Xu Guangyao's poor management, they had previously relied heavily on famous designer Qin Sisi as head of the design department. However, she jumped ship in the first half of the year, taking three of Minghui Jewelry's key talents with her and directly starting a new company. Although it didn't match Minghui Jewelry's reputation, it had already secured initial funding from venture capital companies and was beginning to make its mark in the industry.

Minghui Jewelry's design department was suddenly left without available talent. The current head of the design department had been transferred from the marketing department and didn't understand design at all.

The entire design department was in a state of panic. When Xu Qingzhu was parachuted in as deputy head, no one had faith in her.

Everyone knew that without renowned designers, Minghui Jewelry would soon reach a dead end.

The current Minghui Jewelry was merely at the end of its rope, unable to hold on much longer. What use was having the young lady parachute in?

Xu Qingzhu was just someone who studied finance.

What did she understand about design?

This year's autumn new product launch had reached the point of nearly falling through¹. Although the design department's dozen or so people were all working overtime, it was just ineffective overtime. Every draft they submitted was unusable - lacking novelty and not impressive. Forget comparing to Minghui Jewelry's work from decades ago; they couldn't even match recent years' standards.

It felt as though time kept moving forward while Minghui Jewelry had been ruthlessly left behind.

After Xu Qingzhu took office, the department head no longer bothered much with affairs.

He didn't really understand this aspect of things anyway. Normally in the office, he just slacked off and read books. After Xu Qingzhu arrived, he was perfectly content to be left in peace.

Moreover, Xu Qingzhu's attitude in the workplace was tough, and she was shrouded in the aura of being the company's young lady and future heir, quickly rallying people's hearts.

Although there were still quite a few who wanted to see her fail, most hoped she could bring vitality to the company.

After all, if Minghui Jewelry went bankrupt, they would all have to find new jobs.

But having people's hearts wasn't enough - you also needed capability.

In this regard, Xu Qingzhu wasn't completely hopeless.

Although she studied finance, her university was a top-tier domestic institution.

She hadn't been closed-minded during her studies and knew quite a few people.

She was currently actively contacting former friends to see if she could find suitable designers.

She was also using her years of accumulated keen sense for jewelry to oversee this autumn's new product launch, though it would be quite tiring.

Besides, this was inherently a high-stakes gamble.

In design-related fields, every new product was a high-stakes gamble.

You had to see whether the designer aligned with market trends, whether the designer's vision was unique, and whether you had the luck to hit upon suitable marketing.

Every step for a hit product had to go smoothly.

What Xu Qingzhu was taking over now was a complete mess. She even dreamed about jewelry design drafts at night.

Being able to still smile now could be considered making the best of a bad situation.

Liang Shi didn't yet understand her situation within the company and simply said, "Use it as you like, you don't need to ask me."

"Alright." Xu Qingzhu turned and walked around to the desk. Seeing that she still hadn't left, she glanced at the trash can. "Do you want this book?"

Liang Shi was startled and immediately waved her hands, "No need..."

She finished speaking and turned to leave.

But Xu Qingzhu called out to stop her, "Wait a moment."

Liang Shi turned back, "Ah?"

Xu Qingzhu retrieved the garishly covered book from the clean trash can, walked to the door and handed it to her. "This is your thing after all. It wasn't polite of me to throw it away carelessly. Sorry about that."

"It's fine, it's fine." Liang Shi said, "I wouldn't read it anyway."

"It's still yours." Xu Qingzhu stuffed the book into her arms, and Liang Shi immediately caught it. "Take it and read it. After all, judging a book based on just one passage isn't appropriate."

Liang Shi: "...?"

"Since it could be published, it must have its merits." Xu Qingzhu spoke seriously with calm eyes. "Though the writing in that passage wasn't great, it created very strong visual imagery."

Liang Shi: "?"

"No need..." Liang Shi said.

"Alright. I really need to work now." Xu Qingzhu said, "You don't need to wait for me to sleep. I probably won't finish until quite late."

Liang Shi looked at her and gave a reminder, "Get some rest early."

Xu Qingzhu had already sat down in front of the computer and put on her glasses, cold and distant.

But her focused expression was quite attractive.

Footnotes:

¹ "Opening the skylight" (開天窗) - A publishing/media industry term meaning to have blank space where content should be, essentially failing to deliver promised content on schedule.

Chapter 31 Part 2

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Liang Shi hugged the gaudily covered book "Sweet Daily Life with the Female CEO" and returned to the living room, where cartoons were still playing on the television.

Human curiosity always emerges at the most inopportune times.

Liang Shi first threw the book into the trash can, but after a while, feeling that the cartoons on TV were bland and utterly boring, she had no interest whatsoever.

So she picked the book back out.

She was quite grateful that their trash can was clean.

Usually no one created garbage in the study or living room, and the servants would clean the house spotlessly when they weren't around, leaving not a speck of dust.

Liang Shi picked it up and casually flipped to a page - it was quite proper content.

However, this author's writing was a bit padded; they could write two pages about eating a meal, just writing some interactions during dinner.

How should she put it?

The author grasped the boundaries extremely well, giving the feeling of lingering at the edge of a highway entrance.

It seemed like they were driving¹, yet also seemed like they weren't.

This left Liang Shi bewildered.

So she continued flipping through, and after reading a few pages, some dangerous content indeed appeared - directly driving onto the highway without even fastening a seatbelt.

Liang Shi immediately closed it and threw it back in the trash.

But before long, she was made restless by the emotional storyline in the book, wanting to know what happened next.

So... she picked it up again.

After several rounds of this, Liang Shi turned off the TV.

She also threw the book into a drawer.

Not reading it anymore.

Frustrating.

She simply went to the kitchen to heat up a glass of milk to take to Xu Qingzhu.

When Liang Shi knocked and entered, the desktop computer screen was black.

Only the laptop screen was lit, and the moment she entered, Xu Qingzhu folded the laptop closed.

Liang Shi noticed her small movement but didn't say anything.

It was normal for Xu Qingzhu to be on guard against her, after all, it was company business.

"Drink it while it's hot." Liang Shi placed the milk on her desk. "I'm going to rest."

"Alright, thank you." Xu Qingzhu politely thanked her, smoothly pushing her glasses up.

Liang Shi delivered the milk and walked to the door, then suddenly turned around wanting to discuss something with Xu Qingzhu, but when she turned back and saw that Xu Qingzhu had just opened her laptop and then slammed it shut, her emotions showing some impatience, yet still maintaining a tone of being "dependent on others' kindness" and having to be friendly as she asked: "Is there something else?"

Liang Shi: "..."

All those words got swallowed back down.

"Nothing." Liang Shi smiled. "You go ahead and work."

Xu Qingzhu also sensed she had something to say, so she said, "If you have something to say, you can say it directly. I'll work after you finish."

"You should work first." Liang Shi said, "You still have to go to work tomorrow. I don't have anything important. I'll go out first."

Xu Qingzhu: "...Alright."

Liang Shi made an encouraging gesture toward her, "Fighting!"

Her English pronunciation was very standard.

This made Xu Qingzhu pause, but she immediately said, "Good Night."

An inexplicably random English good night. Liang Shi was momentarily dazed, then gently repeated her phrase: "Good Night."

Still with perfect pronunciation and intonation, comparable to her own, not like someone who had learned just the sounds, but rather like someone with years of English foundation.

But Xu Qingzhu clearly remembered that Liang Shi used to be someone who would be mocked for her pronunciation even when saying "No Problem."

How did Liang Shi used to say it?

She would wave her hand grandly and laugh carelessly: "In the future, they'll all have to learn Chinese. Why should I learn so much English? Besides, I can speak Chinese just fine. And speaking of which, how much do translators cost these days? If I want to travel abroad, can't I just pay for a translator? They'd have to be available on call."

That tone had quite the flavor of a nouveau riche who had struck it rich overnight.

But just now, Liang Shi had been very confident and casual.

Just pure spontaneous speech, without any intention of showing off her learning or superiority.

However, a simple "Fighting" couldn't really display her abilities.

But it was this kind of casually revealed confidence that made people feel she had deep foundations.

"Hey, Blanche." A voice from the study suddenly interrupted Xu Qingzhu's thoughts. She reopened her laptop, and on the screen was a blonde, blue-eyed face speaking fluent English: "Is that your lover?"

"Yes." After thinking for a moment, Xu Qingzhu nodded and answered in equally fluent English, "That's my wife."

The other person expressed surprise, "Your wife has a very nice voice."

"Thank you." Xu Qingzhu didn't want to spend time on this topic and directly changed the subject: "Are you really not considering coming to develop your career domestically?"

"That depends on how much sincerity you have. I don't have any relatives here either, but after all, this is where I grew up." The other person said, "Blanche, you know that place is a sad place for me."

"Ah well." Xu Qingzhu smiled helplessly, "Who told you to leave without saying anything back then? Isn't it normal for Cherry to be angry? And you didn't even try to coax her."

"I was afraid she'd be sad." The other person sighed, "But who knew she'd directly dump me and get a new girlfriend. I was the one who got abandoned."

"Cherry is single now." Xu Qingzhu said, "I just talked to her on the phone yesterday. I'm planning to meet with her tomorrow. She's opened a niche studio now, doing custom jewelry, became a small boss. Life is pretty good, but..."

The other person immediately said, "After you meet with Cherry tomorrow, can you help me ask if I come back to the country, will she kill me?"

Xu Qingzhu was amused by her, "If you decide to come back, I can protect you. Even if Cherry comes at you with a knife, I'd definitely be the first one to get hurt."

The two chatted for a while longer, with the other person asking about her personal life.

For instance, when did she get married, why didn't she mention it, not being considerate at all.

She also said that if she came back to the country, she would definitely make her wife treat them to dinner, and Xu Qingzhu readily agreed.

Finally, the other person asked, "Your wife really has a nice voice. Is she a singer?"

"No." Xu Qingzhu said, "She's..."

She thought for a long time but still couldn't come up with an appropriate title to describe Liang Shi's current state.

She could only smile helplessly: "When you meet, let her tell you herself."

After the other person agreed, she suddenly said, "Blanche, it's been so long and you're still so clever, always setting traps for me."

"Isn't that because you let me?" Xu Qingzhu said.

The other person paused, "OMG. I suddenly realized you're only 23, you got married so early."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

She smiled, "When you meet the right person, you just get married."

She didn't mention at all that it was because of the Xu family's business crisis back then that she had no choice but to marry.

"So you finished your MBA?" the other person asked again.

"Finished, graduated in the first half of this year."

"So you got married right after graduation? Getting both certificates² at the same time." The other person said, "I definitely have to meet this person when I return to the country - who could conquer our campus goddess. I hope she won't disappoint me."

Xu Qingzhu nodded, continuing to entice her, "As long as you come back, I'll definitely introduce you."

Whether they actually meet or not, first trick her into returning to the country.

The two chatted in English for half an hour before hanging up.

Footnotes:

¹ "Driving" - Internet slang referring to writing or content with sexual/romantic themes

² "Both certificates" - Referring to a marriage certificate and diploma/degree certificate

Chapter 31 Part 3

After hanging up the video call, Xu Qingzhu reopened the study computer. The design drafts submitted by the design department were completely unusable now - they absolutely couldn't be presented as mature works at the launch event.

The autumn new product launch was imminent.

If this succeeded, Minghui Jewelry could still struggle on for a while longer, but if it failed, they'd probably have to declare bankruptcy within a few months.

The pressure on Xu Qingzhu's shoulders was enormous.

In desperation, she could only turn to former friends for help.

The person she'd just video-called was Sally, an American whose Chinese name was Yang Zhou.

When she first came to China, she really liked a poem line about "fireworks descending on Yangzhou in March," so she gave herself that Chinese name.

She had met her through the mountaineering club. Both she and Cherry were jewelry design students.

Back then in the mountaineering club, Xu Qingzhu had been the youngest.

Xu Qingzhu had never attended elementary school. Because of that kidnapping incident, she went through a long period of not speaking, just staying at home reading books.

Her father hired private tutors for her. Although she didn't speak, she could completely absorb what the teachers taught, and every time she took exams, her scores were extremely high.

Later, when her condition improved somewhat, her father directly arranged for her to take the middle school entrance exam. She started middle school at age ten, younger than all her classmates.

At that time she was also small in stature, sitting in the first row by the window. Everyone knew she had psychological issues, so no one dared play with her. All her joy came from reading books.

One year her old illness relapsed and she didn't go to school.

This was equivalent to repeating eighth grade for a year.

Later, she entered Haicheng No. 1 High School with high scores, then got into Qingyi University with high scores, majoring in finance.

When choosing her graduate direction, she pursued an MBA. She had received her marriage certificate with Liang Shi before even getting her hands on her two-year MBA degree certificate.

That's why Sally had been so surprised earlier.

When she got married back then, she had felt somewhat inferior, so she didn't notify too many friends from school.

She had even lost contact with everyone after graduation, only liking others' social media posts during holidays and New Year.

Sally and Cherry had each developed their careers after graduation. The two had been a very loving couple, but because Sally's mother became seriously ill during their graduation year, Sally's original plan to stay in the country was disrupted. Without discussing it with Cherry, she directly bought a ticket and flew back to America, which made Cherry angry enough to break up directly.

At the time, Xu Qingzhu had felt sorry for both of them.

It was only these past couple days that she had reconnected with Cherry.

Cherry's Chinese name was Lin Luoxi, currently the boss of Luoxi Studio.

If Minghui Jewelry hadn't reached such straits, Xu Qingzhu wouldn't have been able to bring herself to ask them for help.

Lin Luoxi's design talent was acknowledged as excellent. Her graduation project had been shortlisted for an international design competition and won third prize, once praised in the industry as a design genius with the nickname "Little Su Yao."

Many companies had extended olive branches to her, but Lin Luoxi only asked Xu Qingzhu, "Are you joining your family company?"

Xu Qingzhu said she planned to pursue graduate studies first and would decide later. Lin Luoxi went directly into entrepreneurship and told her, "Call me anytime if you need anything."

Lin Luoxi had attended her wedding and looked at Liang Shi with a complex expression, though she didn't say anything later.

She probably felt that it was a done deal - everyone had their own choices - so she just advised, "Keep your guard up."

Xu Qingzhu had already arranged to have dinner with Lin Luoxi tomorrow evening. She just hoped everything would go smoothly.

Looking at the design drafts on the computer screen, Xu Qingzhu frowned, her mind too chaotic to focus.

When had Liang Shi's English become so good?

After a long while, she sent a message to her psychiatrist, Dr. Gu Junru: [Dr. Gu, if someone has multiple personalities, would their skills change?]

Dr. Gu was still awake and replied immediately: [Be specific?]

Xu Qingzhu: [Her English used to be very poor, ignorant and uneducated, but now her English pronunciation is very standard and she can express some quite impressive viewpoints.]

Dr. Gu: [Is this about your wife?]

Xu Qingzhu: [...]

Dr. Gu quickly sent another message: [Dr. Zhao and I have discussed this issue and unanimously believe that professional examination is needed for confirmation.]

[Because multiple personalities could very likely involve memory segmentation, where one personality takes on her bad memories and certain abilities. But statistically speaking, the possibility of this happening is extremely remote, so further examination is needed.]

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What Liang Shi had wanted to discuss with Xu Qingzhu earlier was that since Xu Qingya had left their home, the two of them could live separately.

But seeing that Xu Qingzhu was busy, and she had just entered the company and was probably dealing with a complete mess, she didn't want to waste her time.

After leaving, Liang Shi sat on the sofa for a while. Feeling somewhat drowsy, she went upstairs to pack her things.

During her time at the villa, she had pretty much figured out all the rooms.

She really liked the second room from the left downstairs - bright and airy with good ventilation, spacious, and even had a walk-in closet.

So she planned to move there.

Liang Shi didn't have many belongings. Most of the clothes in the closet belonged to the original owner - all gaudy colors.

She had only bought a few pieces since transmigrating, so packing was convenient. Then there were the pillow and bedding.

That afternoon when Liang Shi returned, she had the servants put new sheets on that room and also place several spare sets of bedding and pillowcases.

However, she quite liked the set she'd been using, so she planned to take it downstairs.

Besides, Xu Qingzhu might not want to see her things left in the room.

Liang Shi planned to have the servants donate all those clothes in the closet tomorrow, to see which factory could recycle and remake these items.

She returned to the room and folded the bedding neatly, then stacked the pillow on top. The sheets had gotten wrinkled, so she simply remade the bed, and also folded Xu Qingzhu's bedding neatly and smoothly.

Xu Qingzhu had the habit of changing pillowcases daily. She felt that Xu Qingzhu would probably finish work quite late tonight, so after some hesitation, she took a new pillowcase from the closet, planning to help her change it.

But when Liang Shi picked up Xu Qingzhu's pillow, she was shocked.

There was a pair of scissors under her pillow.

...

No wonder she was willing to sleep in the same bed with her - was she planning to use scissors if she was forced into anything?

Liang Shi felt a chill down her back.

This was quite ruthless too.

However, it made sense for Xu Qingzhu to keep scissors under her pillow for self-protection.

She helped Xu Qingzhu put on the new pillowcase, threw the old one in the laundry basket, and put the book that was on her bedside into the drawer. But when she opened the drawer, she saw a utility knife.

...

Liang Shi felt that Xu Qingzhu wasn't just ruthless.

She was a wolf in sheep's clothing¹.

She didn't touch the other person's things, but wrote a note and stuck it on the bedside table, then turned on the bedside lamp on her side, adjusting it to an appropriate brightness. Before leaving, she also turned on the floor light by the door.

Footnotes:

¹ "Wolf in sheep's clothing" - The original Chinese "狼人" is a play on words between "狠人" (ruthless person) and "狼人" (werewolf/wolf person), suggesting someone even more extreme than just being ruthless.

Chapter 31 Part 4

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Xu Qingzhu only returned to work after organizing her thoughts, finishing past midnight.

She removed her glasses and pressed her temples, then closed the computer and went upstairs.

Afraid of disturbing Liang Shi, she deliberately slowed her steps.

But after going upstairs, she discovered that Liang Shi wasn't there.

The two sets of bedding on the bed had become one, and a pillow was missing.

She turned on the room light. The curtains had been drawn, the carpet had been newly changed, and there was even a beautiful transparent vase on the cabinet with daffodils in it.

She could faintly smell a light fragrance.

All the furnishings in this room proved that Liang Shi had come back, but the person had vanished again.

She saw a note on the bedside table that read: [Your sister isn't here anymore, so you don't need to feel awkward acting with me. I moved downstairs to live. This room is for you. Remember to set your morning alarm. If you want breakfast, please come downstairs at eight o'clock. Don't work too hard, sleep early, and sweet dreams. ^-^]

Her handwriting was neat and beautiful, excellent small script.

Of course, Xu Qingzhu had seen Liang Shi's handwriting before, and it was completely different from this note - like heaven and earth.

She frowned and put down the note, then turned on her phone which had died and shut off. Besides receiving company messages, she also saw a message from Liang Shi asking if she was coming back for dinner.

She didn't check what time it was sent, so she casually replied: [Sorry, I just saw the message. My phone was dead earlier.]

The other person didn't reply, probably asleep.

Xu Qingzhu instinctively wanted to go downstairs to see which room she was sleeping in, but halfway down the stairs she realized she was being crazy.

After Xu Qingya left, it was normal for them to live separately.

In fact, after some time, when the company stabilized and her father's emotions stabilized, they were going to divorce.

Besides, it was already so late - if she went down, she might disturb the other person's sleep.

So she turned around to go back, but the living room lights had already been turned off by her, and there was no light on the second floor either. Only dim moonlight refracted from downstairs. She was already a bit nearsighted, and with night blindness, she couldn't see clearly at all. She carefully stepped upstairs first, which went fine.

But there was one stair step that was higher than the others. She was thinking about problems and didn't notice, stepping right into the stair. It hurt so much she gasped, taking a long time to recover.

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Early the next morning.

Liang Shi woke up promptly at seven, opened the windows to ventilate the room, and did a set of aerobic exercises.

The biggest difference between the original owner's body and hers was - abs.

Her original body had abs because she always maintained exercise.

But the original owner relied entirely on good genes to avoid getting a beer belly. Eating and drinking recklessly all day, how could she possibly have abs?

Liang Shi actually didn't pursue such things, she just felt that exercise could make people feel cheerful and maintain physical health.

After finishing a set of aerobic exercises, it was exactly seven-thirty. She went to the kitchen to make breakfast.

The simplest fat-loss sandwich. She wasn't sure if Xu Qingzhu would come downstairs to eat, but still made her portion.

At seven-fifty, Xu Qingzhu came downstairs punctually.

She had already changed into a blouse with a light-colored blazer draped over her arm, hair casually pinned up, wearing light makeup with what looked like a bean paste colored lipstick.

High-end "no-makeup" makeup.

When Liang Shi saw her, she greeted her, "Morning."

Xu Qingzhu nodded at her. Neither mentioned last night's separate sleeping arrangement - it was a tacit understanding.

However, Xu Qingzhu was limping as she came downstairs, holding the stair railing and coming down slowly.

Liang Shi asked her, "What happened?"

Xu Qingzhu sighed, "I kicked the stairs when going up last night."

"No lights?" Liang Shi handed her the sandwich she'd made. "Be more careful next time."

"No, the living room was pitch black." Xu Qingzhu said, "The weather wasn't good yesterday either."

"What does this have to do with the weather?" Liang Shi said.

"Good weather would have moonlight, but there wasn't any last night. Plus I have night blindness, so not being able to see clearly is normal."

Liang Shi: "..."

While Xu Qingzhu ate, she was already cleaning up her own dishes. "Can you still drive later?"

Xu Qingzhu moved her foot slightly, wincing from the pain, but stubbornly said: "Should be fine."

"It hurts that much?" Liang Shi looked at her foot - the ankle was somewhat bruised but not swollen. "How about we go to the hospital first to check?"

"No, I have a meeting at nine-thirty." Xu Qingzhu said, "It's nothing serious."

"It's already bruised. Let's see if the bone is displaced or something." Liang Shi said, "Eat quickly. I'll drive you to the hospital first, then take you to work."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

She ate while asking indistinctly, "Don't you have work?"

"I do." Liang Shi said, "But whether I go or not makes no difference now. Our group doesn't really need me. Unlike you - you have to manage everything."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

"Besides, I'll just take you to the company and then go to work." Liang Shi said, "It won't delay much time, and it's still early now."

Xu Qingzhu looked at her foot. Moving it even slightly really hurt, so she didn't refuse: "Thank you."

Hearing this familiar "thank you," Liang Shi felt mixed emotions.

She looked at her again and again.

Xu Qingzhu belatedly realized, "Did I say thank you again just now?"

Liang Shi nodded, "Yes."

"But this really deserves thanks." Xu Qingzhu said.

Liang Shi was silent for two seconds: "...How about you think about the awful things I did before?"

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

"Never mind, don't think about it." Liang Shi said, "Early morning isn't good for physical and mental health."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

She said quietly, "Those things you did before were indeed awful, but..."

"But what?" Liang Shi asked.

Xu Qingzhu paused, "Nothing."

After eating, Xu Qingzhu planned to wash the dishes, but Liang Shi told her to get her bag and change shoes to prepare to leave - Liang Shi would wash the dishes.

Xu Qingzhu had to say thanks again.

Liang Shi's movements paused, and she said stiffly, "You're welcome."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

Chapter 31 Part 5

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Xu Qingzhu's foot wasn't seriously injured - just a minor sprain without bone damage. The doctor applied some medicine and did a simple bandage, and that was it.

When Liang Shi brought Xu Qingzhu to the company, it was exactly eight-fifty.

She even left Xu Qingzhu ten minutes to get upstairs.

By the time she reached her own company, it was already nine-thirty.

Half an hour late.

When she clocked in, that mechanical electronic voice sounded again, once more subjecting her to public execution in front of everyone.

Everyone in the office area looked over, but then turned away, not thinking it was a big deal.

What could it be anyway?

Although she was new, on her first day she had taken down the arrogant Editor-in-Chief Sun. Everyone knew she wasn't simple.

Being late - what was that? Was it even an issue?

Not at all.

Even if she didn't come for a whole day and still got paid, it had nothing to do with these working people.

Besides, as long as the magazine department director position remained vacant, it meant this newcomer could be promoted to magazine department director at any time.

No one would point fingers at someone with connections.

So everyone was quite calm. After all, when Liang Shi hadn't come to the company yesterday, everyone had already privately discussed this new employee.

Opinions about her identity varied, but according to a well-informed colleague's conclusion, she was the uneducated and arrogant third young lady of the Liang family.

Colleagues from the HR department were quite shocked to hear that she hadn't ransacked their department but had only fired Editor-in-Chief Sun.

Because that person had previously caused a bloodbath in the HR department - more outrageous than a destructive husky¹. The HR director's office was left in complete disarray, and they almost quit.

Why did they stay in the end?

Probably due to life's pressures.

In any case, everyone knew not to provoke this person.

Liang Shi had nothing to do all morning. Everyone was busy with their own work. The little girl next to her workstation was still there, still quietly reading.

And she was reading "Pride and Prejudice."

She wondered if such a young child could understand it.

She was so quiet that her presence could easily be ignored.

She must be some colleague's child.

With nothing else to do, Liang Shi found a movie to watch, wearing headphones. She was watching a science fiction film. In this world, the development of sci-fi films was faster than in her original world. Perhaps with gender differentiation, human intelligence had generally improved, leading to better understanding of science fiction.

The one she was watching was called "Borders," with quite a grand production.

Halfway through, she noticed something beside her. Turning her head, she saw the little girl leaning over to watch, staring intently.

This movie was entirely in English. Although there were subtitles, many words weren't common, and some were even obscure - not very friendly for such a young child.

Liang Shi wouldn't deprive a child of the joy of watching movies, but still asked, "Can you understand it?"

The little girl's voice was crisp: "Is it about aliens invading Earth? That person just now is a spy, right?"

Liang Shi: "..."

She was truly surprised.

Because in the known plot, that person had always existed as an Earthling, with only subtle hints planted, never explicitly stating that he was a spy.

Liang Shi had extensive film knowledge, so she guessed that person was a spy, but she hadn't expected such a young girl to see through it at first glance.

She couldn't help but be curious: "Little friend, how old are you?"

The little girl's eyes were still fixed on her computer. Liang Shi took off her headphones and paused the movie, looking at her seriously.

With the movie paused, the little girl seemed a bit disappointed, but she politely answered, "I'm six years old."

"You're the same age as my niece!" Liang Shi said. "My niece is also six this year. But don't you go to school?"

She said frankly, "I got in a fight with a classmate and was ordered to reflect for a month."

"And you're proud of it?" Editorial team leader Zhou Li turned around to look at her, and she lowered her head.

Liang Shi immediately understood - this was their team leader's daughter.

"I was clearly helping someone in need!" the little girl said quietly.

Zhou Li glanced at her: "Don't disturb your mother's colleague's work."

"It's fine," Liang Shi said. "You go ahead with your work. I have nothing to do anyway."

After saying this, she added, "If you have anything you need me to do, just let me know."

Zhou Li looked at her meaningfully: "Not at the moment, but you need to familiarize yourself with the company employee handbook. There's a meeting at three this afternoon. After the meeting, I'll discuss your future work content with you."

"Okay."

After that, Zhou Li immersed herself in work and stopped paying attention to the little girl.

Liang Shi asked the little girl, "What's your name?"

"Rainbow," the little girl said. "Zhou Caihong."

"Your English pronunciation is so standard!" Liang Shi said. "Have you lived abroad?"

"My father is a foreigner, currently abroad," Rainbow said. "I've always been with my mother - bilingual education."

She spoke nothing like a six-year-old child - clear and logical, with precise word choice.

Liang Shi asked her again, "Can you understand English?"

Rainbow said, "Simple things, yes."

So Liang Shi handed her an earbud: "Want to watch together?"

Rainbow pulled over a chair and sat beside her.

Footnotes:

¹ "Destructive husky" - A common internet reference in Chinese culture, referring to Siberian Huskies' reputation for being hyperactive and destructive when bored, often used to describe chaotic or destructive behavior.

Chapter 31 Part 6

After watching the film, Liang Shi was amazed that a six-year-old girl could discuss foreign science fiction films so eloquently and with such insight.

So she asked again, "Can you understand 'Pride and Prejudice' too?"

Rainbow nodded, "More or less."

Rainbow then briefly recounted the plot and gave a simple evaluation of the protagonists.

Liang Shi: "..."

This must be the legendary genius girl!

"Sister, what's your name?" Rainbow asked.

"I'm Liang Shi."

As she spoke, she took off her suit jacket, leaving only a white shirt with the top button undone.

The cubicle was a bit warm, so she rolled up her shirt sleeves. Rainbow suddenly frowned and said, "Sister, your bracelet looks very familiar."

"Huh?" Liang Shi was surprised. "This was given to me by my wife."

It was the bracelet she had bought at the auction, and Liang Shi had been wearing it ever since.

She had promised Xu Qingzhu she wouldn't lose it, so she kept it carefully.

However, this bracelet was quite old, with some scratches on it. When she first got it, it was tarnished - a common occurrence with silver items that haven't been worn for a long time. After wearing it for a few days, it had regained some brightness.

"Mm." Rainbow stared at the bracelet, then asked, "Can I take a closer look?"

Liang Shi extended her hand to her, still doubtfully saying, "This was bought at an auction, so you shouldn't have seen it anywhere else. It might just be similar."

"No," Rainbow said. "It's exactly the same... I remember where I've seen it."

Logically, items given to auctions would have been personally used.

But this bracelet was an anonymous donation, and the owner of this item had been dead for many years.

If Rainbow had really seen this bracelet before, it meant that person had a close relationship with the Sheng family.

Even Xu Qingzhu hadn't received her grandmother's heirloom, so the person who owned this bracelet should have been someone who almost became her daughter-in-law.

Integrating the information she had seen online before, Liang Shi thought the owner of this item should be Su Yao?

But supposedly, Sheng Qinglin and she had already broken up before his death.

Online information was mixed, making it hard to distinguish truth from fiction.

But Liang Shi felt this was a clue, so she asked, "Where did you see it?"

"In our teacher's hands," Rainbow said. "During one class, our class kept making jingling sounds. The teacher confiscated Su Yu's toy, and when she passed by me, I saw this bracelet."

"Are you sure it's the same one?" Liang Shi asked.

Could she really be trusted after seeing it only once?

Zhou Li, who had been working, suddenly turned around and said firmly, "You can trust her."

Liang Shi: "Huh?"

"She has a photographic memory," Zhou Li said.

Liang Shi: "..."

Liang Shi felt she had received a huge shock.

So she really was a genius girl!

"Who is Su Yu?" Liang Shi asked.

"Su Yu is Su Yu," Rainbow frowned. "A not very likeable little kid."

Liang Shi: "..."

"What about your teacher?" Liang Shi asked. "What's your teacher's name? Do you have her contact information? The teacher who confiscated this bracelet."

Rainbow answered without hesitation, "Our teacher is called Qi Jiao, her phone number is xxxxx."

She recited a string of numbers, which Liang Shi quickly wrote down. She also asked about Rainbow's kindergarten, planning to visit this teacher when she had time, and also meet Su Yu.

However, when writing down the name Qi Jiao, she felt something was strange about it, as if she had seen it before.

But she wanted to figure out the origin of this bracelet.

Maybe she could even clarify Xu Qingzhu's background.

Liang Shi had once asked Qiu Zimin - everyone said Xu Qingzhu wasn't biological, so who were her birth parents?

Qiu Zimin answered impatiently, "Who knows which orphanage they adopted her from? Sheng Linlang never even had a belly back then - where would such a daughter come from? I heard she was adopted from Angel Orphanage, but that place closed down long ago. After all these years, what's the point of investigating her background? Even if the Xu family gets better in the future, their family assets will belong to her sister. What share would she have?"

Liang Shi didn't discuss this issue in depth with her.

But Liang Shi didn't think Xu Qingzhu was adopted from an orphanage. Just looking at her face, which was fifty percent similar to Xu Qingya's, it didn't seem likely.

She was more inclined to believe that Xu Qingzhu was Sheng Qinglin's child.

But as for who Sheng Qinglin had her with, that remained unknown.

After all, talented men were often promiscuous. Although he had Su Yao as his official girlfriend at the time, there were often rumors about other women.

There was even a report that sorted through Sheng Qinglin's rumored romantic interests from back then, stating with certainty that he and Su Yao had broken up a year before his death.

And the year Sheng Qinglin died, Xu Qingzhu hadn't been born yet.

So... it truly remained a mystery.

Chapter 31 Part 7

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In the afternoon, Liang Shi was assigned work - organizing interview materials.

Each member of the editorial team had already been assigned tasks. Tomorrow they would go to a film set to interview popular artist Zhao Ying, and the interviewing editor needed an assistant. Zhou Li asked if she could do it.

Liang Shi readily agreed.

After assigning the tasks, Zhou Li privately asked her, "Can I treat you as a newcomer or intern?"

"Yes," Liang Shi said.

Zhou Li was silent for a moment. "If you want to learn things here, I won't be polite with you. Please don't be late in the future - being half an hour late counts as absence. If you really have an emergency, you can ask me for leave. I'll send you everyone's contact numbers in the editorial team later."

Liang Shi nodded with a continuous smile, "Okay."

"I don't care which university you graduated from or what your major was. Since you have no work experience, you start from the bottom. Everyone in the editorial team, and even colleagues in the magazine department, are your seniors. Everyone has something you can learn from," Zhou Li said seriously. "Don't use your privileges to run amok in the magazine department. If you still think you're here to slack off, you can tell me now. I'm just a working person - I won't force you to do things..."

"It's fine, no need," Liang Shi immediately said. "Just treat me like an ordinary intern. I can do anything."

"You know PS, photography, and copywriting?" Zhou Li asked.

Liang Shi said, "I also know a little bit about layout."

She had learned all sorts of things before.

"Good," Zhou Li said. "You'll assist with this interview first. Zhao Ying has a bad temper, and we spent a lot of effort scheduling time with her. If you find her unpleasant, you can leave early - don't get into arguments with her. I know your..."

"No, no," Liang Shi said helplessly. "Team leader, my temper really isn't that bad."

It was the original owner who was bad!

Zhou Li smiled slightly, "Alright, that's all for now. We'll see how you perform afterward."

Liang Shi knew that Zhou Li was treating her as an employee to train and giving her opportunities for experience.

Having such seniors in the workplace was fortunate.

Liang Shi happily said to her, "Thank you, team leader. I'll definitely work hard!"

When she returned to her seat, Rainbow asked her in confusion, "Why are you so happy when they give you work to do?"

"Because cold violence is scarier than being tired," Liang Shi said. "People learn things through hard work. Your mother is teaching me."

Rainbow: "...Okay then."

Although the little girl was very smart, she still couldn't understand the interpersonal dynamics of the adult world.

That afternoon, Liang Shi organized all the materials needed for tomorrow's interview and handed them to Li Ran, the editor responsible for field interviews, before the end of work.

Li Ran looked at her materials, originally flipping through them without much expectation, already mentally prepared to work overtime at home that evening. But unexpectedly, these materials impressed her.

She had organized the stories about Zhao Ying and her connections to BARE clearly and concisely.

Everything was well-structured, and there was even an interview outline at the end.

When Liang Shi handed it to her, she said, "Sister Ran, I practiced writing an interview outline. Could you help me look at it? I'm bothering you - just treat it like grading homework. I know you have rich interview experience, so I'm shamelessly asking for advice. If you could give me some feedback, I'd be extremely grateful."

This address of "Sister Ran" completely stunned Li Ran.

Combined with Liang Shi's slightly smiling expression and humble attitude, it seemed like a completely different person from the one who had stood there sternly questioning Editor-in-Chief Sun that day.

It also didn't match the rumored image of the arrogant and domineering Third Miss Liang.

In that instant, Li Ran's knees went weak and she almost knelt down.

She steadied herself against the desk and barely regained some composure. "Alright, I'll help you look at it, but I have to work overtime tonight preparing some things, so I can't give you feedback immediately. I'll tell you before the end of work tomorrow, okay?"

"That's fine," Liang Shi said. "Thank you, Sister Ran."

Li Ran: "...No trouble at all."

Her voice was trembling as she spoke.

After leaving the office building, a colleague laughed at her, "Is it really necessary to be that scared?"

Li Ran: "You don't know how terrifying she used to be."

Colleague: "..."

Liang Shi had no idea that her behavior had scared Li Ran half to death.

After going home, she used the study computer to review all the interview materials again and watched all of Zhao Ying's previous interviews, extracting useful information.

Then she turned off the lights and returned to her room to rest.

Chapter 31-8

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Xu Qingzhu went to meet Cherry, chatting until very late and having a little alcohol. When she took a taxi home, it was already close to ten o'clock.

She first went to the study to send an email to Sally, telling her that Cherry had agreed to come help at Minghui Jewelry and didn't mind working together with her. She herself would also show 120% sincerity, hoping Sally could return to the country to help her get through this difficult time.

After sending the email, she saw a new document on the computer desktop that hadn't been renamed. She thought it was hers and clicked it open, only to discover it was materials organized by Liang Shi.

She actually read through it from beginning to end, and there were even some notes that Liang Shi had made herself.

For a newcomer, it was quite good, but it could be further improved.

Xu Qingzhu made some minor revisions for her, then saved and closed the computer.

After coming out of the study, she found that the chandelier in the living room was turned off.

But the house still glowed with warm yellow light. She crouched down to look and found a light strip along the wall extending from the first floor all the way to both sides of the staircase, and there was also a hidden line under the stairs, illuminating each step clearly.

A stream of warmth flowed through Xu Qingzhu's heart.

Having already had some alcohol, her blood rushed to her head and she went to knock on the doors on the first floor. She knocked on two rooms - both were empty.

When she was about to knock on the third room, she had just raised her head when the door automatically opened.

"Huh? Does our house have automatic doors?" Xu Qingzhu wondered.

"No." Liang Shi was still watching the interview clips of Zhao Ying. Hearing continuous knocking sounds, she thought Xu Qingzhu was trapped outside and couldn't get in, so she opened the door. But then she smelled a faint scent of alcohol and asked, "Did you drink?"

Xu Qingzhu nodded, "Met a classmate, had a little."

Liang Shi asked, "Are you drunk?"

"Not really." Xu Qingzhu asked, "Did you turn on the lights on the stairs?"

"The housekeeper did," Liang Shi said, "It'll stay on all night, just remember to watch your step from now on."

"Okay~" Xu Qingzhu puffed out her cheeks, then leaned against her door and suddenly bowed ninety degrees to Liang Shi, "Thank you!"

Liang Shi: "..."

She wondered if Xu Qingzhu would still remember this tomorrow?

Her drunk behavior of blanking out had quite the flavor of "as long as I'm not embarrassed, then it's someone else who's embarrassed."

Liang Shi asked, "Have you washed up yet?"

Xu Qingzhu shook her head, "Not yet, I'm going to wash up now."

Good, she wasn't completely drunk.

But she was walking a bit unsteadily, so Liang Shi felt uneasy and went out to help her upstairs.

Back upstairs, Liang Shi turned on the lights. Xu Qingzhu looked at the empty bed and said softly, "Don't they say it takes twenty-one days for a person to form a habit? Why is it that after sleeping with you for a few days, when you weren't there yesterday, the bed felt a little cold?"

Liang Shi: "The temperature dropped last night."

Xu Qingzhu: "So I added an extra blanket."

Liang Shi: "...Good job."

She helped Xu Qingzhu to the bathroom. Xu Qingzhu looked in the mirror and suddenly said, "Liang Shi, can you sing me a song?"

Liang Shi: "?"

What kind of request was this?

Xu Qingzhu blinked, "Can you? If not, I'll just go to sleep."

Liang Shi: "...You haven't washed up yet."

"I can skip washing up."

"..."

Liang Shi said, "So if I sing, you'll wash up?"

Xu Qingzhu answered crisply, "Yes!"

Liang Shi: "..."

Oh my god.

Did Xu Qingzhu know she was like this when drunk?

She really wanted to record this and show it to the sober Xu Qingzhu tomorrow.

And use it to warn her: please don't drink anymore in the future!

But Liang Shi's phone was left in the downstairs room, so she could only coax Xu Qingzhu to sleep for now.

She cleared her throat and began to sing, "The rain blocking the road is like snow, are you crying and cold..."

It was a Cantonese song she used to listen to often.

Unexpectedly, Xu Qingzhu froze, then frowned and interrupted her, "I want to hear an English song!"

Liang Shi paused, thinking what a strange request.

While she was still hesitating, Xu Qingzhu snorted coldly, her cool voice softening as if acting coquettishly, "Hurry up~ the water is getting cold."

Liang Shi: "..."

Her heartbeat suddenly skipped a beat. She helplessly replied, "Okay."

After a few seconds, she began to sing: "I was found on the ground by the fountain at Valder fields and was almost dry..."

This song had once been her phone ringtone. The melody was gentle and very healing.

Her English was standard, and even singing a cappella didn't affect how pleasant it sounded.

Xu Qingzhu also began washing her face to the sound of her singing.

When the song finished, Xu Qingzhu had also finished washing up. She consciously took off her outer clothes, lay on the bed, and even blinked her big eyes at her saying, "Good Night!"

Liang Shi thought to herself, finally it's over. She dimmed the bedside lamp for her, "Good night."

Xu Qingzhu quickly closed her eyes and made steady breathing sounds.

Liang Shi stayed in the room for a while, and seeing that she was fast asleep, she left the room.

But as soon as she walked out, Xu Qingzhu opened her eyes. Those eyes showed no trace of the previous confusion; instead, they were completely clear.

She even took out her phone to message Dr. Gu: [I discovered another difference - she sings much better than before.]

Gu Junru: [I'll come to your villa this week to take a look, is that convenient?]

Xu Qingzhu: [Yes.]

Chapter 31-9

//

The drama that Zhao Ying was currently filming was called "Thirty-Year-Old Me," a modern urban workplace drama where Zhao Ying played the female lead.

This interview with her mainly focused on her understanding of BARE.

Because Zhao Ying had another nickname in the industry called "Human Wealth Blossom," she carried bags worth 70,000+ yuan daily and wore accessories starting at six figures, making her quite a loyal BARE customer.

On the way to the interview, Liang Shi suddenly became interested in her surname.

Surnamed Zhao, and so wealthy.

So she took out her phone to message Zhao Xuning: [Do you know Zhao Ying?]

After a while, Zhao Xuning replied: [She's my cousin.]

Liang Shi: "..."

The world was indeed very small.

Liang Shi went out for the interview with Li Ran, along with colleagues from the magazine department's camera crew. After getting in the car, Li Ran kept reading through the interview outline, afraid of making mistakes later.

But despite being busy, she still greeted Liang Shi, "Your interview outline was well done. I picked a few questions you wrote to use in today's interview script, just letting you know. I'll also report this truthfully to the boss later."

"Okay, it's my honor." Liang Shi was secretly delighted.

After they arrived at the film crew, there were dedicated reception staff who led them to Zhao Ying's tent.

Today's filming was all outdoor scenes, so the dressing room was just a set-up tent. Zhao Ying's assistant briefed them on some precautions and questions that couldn't be asked.

Li Ran was busy taking notes, while Liang Shi's mind had already flown to the filming scene.

The director was explaining the scene to the actors. Zhao Ying's appearance was too outstanding - you could spot her at a glance. Not only that, she also saw Chen Liuying.

Standing together with Zhao Ying, Chen Liuying seemed a bit lacking.

Zhao Ying was the "Human Wealth Blossom" created with money, while Chen Liuying was the "Internet's First Imperial Alpha"¹ created through marketing. Though their faces were comparable, their temperaments differed.

Moreover, Liang Shi discovered that the Zhao family generally possessed a quality of "I'm very capable but I don't say it, yet you can tell at a glance that I'm different from others."

Zhao Xuning was like this, and so was Zhao Ying.

Over there, they started filming. Chen Liuying's acting wasn't bad, while Zhao Ying's was even better. Their scene together passed in just two takes - they were qualified actors.

Just as they were waiting, the director suddenly shouted: "Says she's not coming and just doesn't come? What? Want to leave a gap in my crew schedule?"

"Won't play the villain? Who was it that said in interviews that she wanted to break through herself? Damn, what the hell!" The director was furious: "Not even famous yet and already acting like a star?! Pulling this on me - I'm putting the word out, anyone who uses her in the future is going against me! Let her be arrogant! Arrogant my ass!"

"Director, what should we do?" someone below asked.

"Film something else first," the director said. "I'll go contact people again."

"But Liuying wraps today, this is her last scene," the person below said. "Liuying enters another crew this afternoon."

Director: "...Damn, where am I supposed to find someone on such short notice?"

The commotion on set was quite loud. Zhao Ying stood there and suddenly made eye contact with Liang Shi.

Liang Shi: "..."

Did Zhao Ying recognize the original host?

Then Zhao Ying said: "Director, what about that one? She looks quite good, quite photogenic, and her outfit today is quite suitable. How about using her?"

Liang Shi: "?"

Footnotes:

¹ Imperial Alpha (禦A): Internet slang referring to a dominant, powerful Alpha character type, often used in marketing celebrity personas in ABO-themed entertainment content.